CONNECT DAILY

Wednesday 21 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- Ofsted's chief inspector has announced a pilot independent complaints review, letting schools challenge whether an inspection's outcome itself was fair - not just how a complaint was handled - after three unions passed no-confidence motions in his leadership this month.
- The teacher pay dispute looks resolved: the NEU has paused its strike ballot after the Education Secretary confirmed schools can keep pension-contribution savings to fund the 3.5% 2026/27 award in full, without clawback.
- Sheffield's finance and performance committee met Monday on the £602k Firth Park/Parkwood SEND and places expansion flagged yesterday - the decision hadn't surfaced publicly by this morning.

→ **For your school:** *Worth a call to the council or Lift Schools for the outcome.*

- Reminder: Sheffield schools break for autumn half term from Monday (26-30 October).

DATES FOR THE DIARY

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

27 Oct 2026 — South Yorkshire Mayoral Combined Authority Board meets.

28 Oct 2026 — Autumn school census return deadline (DfE).

NATIONAL POLICY & ACCOUNTABILITY

▪ **Ofsted launches independent complaints pilot.** Sir Martyn Oliver has announced that schools inspected in 2026/27 can ask an independent reviewer - contracted by DfE, separate from Ofsted - to look at whether an inspection's outcome was fair, not just how a complaint was handled. Where grading is in question, the reviewer can recommend a report card be set aside and the school reinspected. It follows NEU and other unions' votes of no confidence in Oliver's leadership this month. (Schools Week)

▪ **Teacher pay dispute defused.** The NEU has paused its strike ballot after Education Secretary Lucy Powell confirmed schools can keep savings from reduced pension employer contributions to cover the 3.5% 2026/27 pay award, rather than having them clawed back centrally - which the union is calling a fully-funded rise. (Schools Week)

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

▪ **Firth Park/Parkwood outcome still awaited.** As flagged yesterday, Sheffield's finance and performance committee met on Monday to decide on passing £602,000 of government funding to Lift Schools for three SEND rooms and 30 extra Year 7 places at Firth Park Academy, bundled with a temporary expansion at Parkwood Academy. No decision had been reported publicly as of this morning. (The Star)

→ **For your school:** *Worth a call to the council or Lift Schools for the result if either is a feeder or partner.*

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

15%

Share of state-school teachers in England now working in a school with a two-week October half-term, up from 12% in 2025 and 7% in 2023 - driven mainly by academies setting their own calendars. Sheffield schools are taking the standard one week from Monday.

Teacher Tapp survey of 8,112 teachers, reported this week

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.